THE CHOPPING BLOCK



Union tribal affairs minister **Jual Oram** is in a foul mood. The six-time MP, who had earlier indicated he might hang up his boots, has now changed his mind even as he sniffs a conspiracy to oust him. This came after an aide of his was arrested in Odisha for alleged arms trafficking. Oram claims it's all part of a smear campaign by rivals in the BJP to engineer his exit. He has not named the plotters, but offered a dire warning, saying he had the power to "cut off their hands".

ORCHHA ORACLE



BJP executive meetings are for organisational stocktaking, but in Orchha, ex-MLA **Imarti Devi** managed to create some ripples. Spotting minister Krishna Gaur, the Jyotiraditya Scindia loyalist greeted her warmly before offering a rather ambitious blessing: "I hope Ram raja (Lord Ram) makes you the CM." Gaur, caught off guard for a moment, smiled and moved on. The remark was perhaps not random. Gaur is a Yadav (like CM Mohan Yadav), a former Bhopal mayor and daughter-in-law of ex-CM Babulal Gaur.

AFTER YOU...



It all started with state minister **Santosh Suman**, son of Union minister Jitan Ram Manjhi, backing a sub-categorisation of SC/ST reservations. LJP chief **Chirag Paswan** opposed it, saying it alters the spirit of reservations, and added that those backing the 'creamy layer' argument should quit their posts. Suman shot back that Chirag should do so first for opposing a move to help the most deprived. The exchange has given a sharp edge to the contest between the two camps for leadership of the Dalits in Bihar. But then, for all the talk, neither side seems eager to surrender office. The message from both sides: *pehle aap* (after you, please).



Kaushik Deka *with* Ashish Misra, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Rahul Noronha *and* Amitabh Srivastava

ECO WATCH

KAZIRANGA SANCTUARY
RHINOS MAY LOSE BUFFER

By **Jumana Shah**

Assam has proposed to the Union government that Kaziranga National Park's Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ) be cut from a default 10 km to 1 km, reviving a debate on forest habitat versus the demands of urban development. Chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma argued in early August that the current 10 km limit was never formally notified and applied only by default, and that the state wants a "scientifically determined" 1 km zone that clears the way for projects like a stadium in Bokakhat. Days later, Sarma pushed back on criticism saying, "I see a lot of misinformation on Kaziranga's ESZ. Let's be clear...the park area remains unchanged."



Kaziranga is home to the world's largest population of the greater one-horned rhinoceros, which numbered 2,613 in the last census in 2022, an increase of 200 over the previous count in 2018. The 2024 report, 'Status of Tigers in Kaziranga', also found that the big cat population had climbed from 104 adults in 2022 to 148 in 2024, among the highest tiger densities anywhere. During the monsoon floods, these animals rely on the surrounding buffer to reach higher ground in the Karbi Anglong hills—precisely the land a reduced ESZ would open to construction.

The move has drawn much flak from the Opposition, which has pointed fingers at everything from 'large corporate groups' to a contested five-star hotel project near the park and the arrest of rights activist Pranab Doley. While one argument points to the recurring floods as reason enough for protecting Kaziranga's floodplains, activist Brihatrabar Pegu says the Adivasis now fear their land will be lost to corporate development.